

UTT Chapter 03 Assignment

Hello again!

As the semester is moving forward, my homework is piling up and classes are getting a lot harder. I thought taking a Basket Weaving elective would be a piece-of-cake class, but I was definitely wrong. Don't laugh at me. It's been a lot of work!

As part of our freshman orientation, we had to attend a cultural event last weekend. It did interfere with intramural practices, but it was also very interesting. We went to a Middle Eastern gathering where they showcased the food, dress, and traditions of Islam. Most of the food was really good, and it was neat to see how another culture lives.

I sat next to Muhammad, a student I recognized from one of my classes. He told me he grew up a Muslim in the Middle East. When we started talking about Islam, I realized how little I really knew. All I knew was that the attacks of 9/11 were carried out by radical Muslim terrorists, so I guess my mindset towards the religion was initially jaded. I asked Muhammad if he agreed with the 9/11 bombings, and he shook his head emphatically and told me he wasn't "that kind" of Muslim. I didn't know there was more than one kind, so I asked him what kind of Muslim he was.

He told me that he was a normal Muslim who follows the five pillars of Islam, lives closely in line with the Quran, and obeys Allah so he can earn his eternal salvation. I nodded my head in feigned comprehension as I pretended not to be completely ignorant about Islam (which I was), knowing that I'd probably learn about everything from the guys leading this cultural event. But unfortunately for me, this was more of an event for the Muslim students on campus and not a chance to learn about religion. I learned a bit about clothing and food, but they didn't really "teach" me anything about Islam, per se. I'm still kind of confused about the whole thing. I wonder if could you help me?

First off, **what is a Muslim, and what are the five pillars of Islam?** I've heard of Allah, but I don't really know what the difference is between the Muslim god and the Christian God. **What does Islam teach about the nature of God and human beings?** Muhammad mentioned that he believes all the biblical prophets are considered prophets of Islam, including Jesus. Can that be right? **What does Islam really teach about the Bible and Jesus?** He said following the Quran would get you into paradise. **What does Islam teach about salvation?** I feel really ignorant about the subject.

Well, it's late, so I should go to bed. But thanks for your help! I hope you're doing well!

Bye!
-Doug

Doug brought up four different questions; below is a rough outline of possible responses:

1. What is a Muslim, and what are the five pillars of Islam?

Islam means “submission.” Within Islam, children submit to adults, women submit to men, and all submit to Allah; a Muslim is “one who submits” to Allah and the principles of Islam. Every good Muslim is expected to follow the five pillars of Islam:

The first pillar is the ***shahada***, the confession of faith: *There is no God but Allah and Muhammad is his prophet*. This profession, if sincere, makes a person a Muslim.

The second pillar is ***salat***, or prayer. Islam mandates that Muslims pray five times a day, facing Mecca, so as to meditate on Allah and his decrees as well as keep oneself from temptation.

The third pillar is ***zakat***, much like the Christian tithe. Islam requires that followers give 2.5 percent of their income to the poor.

The fourth pillar is the ***sawm***; it involves fasting during Ramadan. This fast prohibits Muslims from eating, smoking, or having sexual relations during the day (these requirements are lifted after sundown).

The fifth pillar is a pilgrimage called ***hajj***. As long as finances and health are conducive to travel, all Muslims are expected to make a pilgrimage to Mecca at least once in their lives. [3.4, 3.8d]

2. What does Islam teach about the nature of God and human beings?

Allah is the Arabic word for “God.” According to Islam, Allah is the one and only God. Unlike the Christian God, he does not exist as three persons. The concept of a triune God is seen as polytheism and is offensive to Muslims. Islam teaches that Allah has always existed, and he created everything in the universe. Unlike the Christian God, Allah is transcendent and does not relate to people on a personal level; rather, he speaks only through the prophets and teachings (Sufism is an exception to the rule). Humans are not made in the image of Allah because Allah does not share his attributes with anyone or anything. He is wrathful and judgmental. To please him, one must either live a very good life or die in the act of jihad. [3.6a, 3.8b]

3. What does Islam teach about the Bible and Jesus?

Islam acknowledges the prophets from the Bible, believing that they were originally prophets of Islam, but their writings were merely corrupted over time. Because the Bible has been corrupted, it no longer contains Allah’s

original message. According to Islam, Jesus was God's prophet, but he wasn't God. God is not one being in three persons. And God would never live among human beings, allow himself to be killed by humans, or selflessly sacrifice himself for the salvation of humanity. Muslims view such a concept of God as weak, and Allah is anything but weak. [3.6b-c]

4. What does Islam teach about salvation?

According to Islam, Jesus was neither God nor the savior of the world. No one can save us; salvation only comes through Allah's mercy. Allah shows mercy on those Muslims who obey his commands. Although Allah only guarantees paradise to those who die in the act of jihad, he is likely to show mercy on those who do good. The Quran uses the metaphor of a balance with one's good deeds weighted against one's bad deeds. A person with more bad deeds is displeasing to God, while a person with more good deeds is pleasing to God. [3.6d]